



The Pilgrim Fathers

The arrival of 102 settlers in Plymouth, Massachusetts on December 11, 1620 is one of the legendary stories of US history. These men, women, and children are lauded as the Pilgrim Fathers, the founders of what became the United States. Yet they were by no means the first Europeans to settle in the country.

BEFORE



HOCHELAGA

The first Europeans to visit America were adventurers rather than settlers.

FRENCH CANADA

Frenchman **Jacques Cartier** explored the St. Lawrence River from 1535 to 1542, and renamed Hochelaga, Mont Réal (Montreal). Fishermen and fur traders followed.

Permanent French settlers arrived later—after the foundation of Québec in 1608.



ALGONQUIN INDIANS

SURVIVAL TECHNIQUES

To survive in this **new and hostile environment**, the French formed alliances with local tribes, notably the Algonquin Indians. The Iroquois tribe later became allies of the British.

In the century after Columbus arrived in the Americas (see pp.228–29), European contact with North America was remarkably limited. The Spanish, obsessed with gold and conquest, concentrated on exploiting the wealthy empires of Central and South America. To the north, the French explored the rich fishing and fur-trapping regions of the St. Lawrence River. Those European navigators who did visit America were more concerned with finding a route around it to Asia than exploring the continent itself.

While the Spanish established bases to protect their bullion fleets, such as St. Augustine in Florida, and the French traded in Canada to the north, it was

the English who first attempted colonization of the eastern seaboard. In 1584 the English adventurer Sir Walter Raleigh established a settlement on Roanoke Island, but lacked the resources to sustain it. The settlement is believed to have been destroyed by the local Croatoan Indians in 1590. By then the defeat of the Spanish Armada in 1588 (see pp. 260–61) gave the English the incentive to attempt to intervene in the relatively undefended and undercolonized continent of North America. In 1607 the Virginia Company of London took advantage of this, and set up a colony in Jamestown, Virginia.

The Pilgrims

The men and women who settled Jamestown came to acquire land and hopefully wealth. Those that landed at New Plymouth in 1620 came to escape religious persecution in Europe. Often described as Puritans, they were more accurately religious dissenters who had left England for the Netherlands in 1608, but then decided to build their own society in a new land. Armed with a Virginia Company land grant, they set sail in the *Mayflower*. After a two-month voyage, they arrived in the New